09 1Sa · 1 Samuel

1 Now there was a man named Elkanah who was from Ramathaim-zophim in the hill country of Ephraim. He was the son of Jeroham, the son of Elihu, the son of Tohu, the son of Zuph, an Ephraimite. [2] He had two wives, one named Hannah and the other Peninnah. And Peninnah had children, but Hannah had none. [3] Year after year Elkanah would go up from his city to worship and sacrifice to the LORD of Hosts at Shiloh, where Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, were priests to the LORD. [4] And whenever the day came for Elkanah to present his sacrifice, he would give portions to his wife Peninnah and to all her sons and daughters. [5] But to Hannah he would give a double portion, for he loved her even though the LORD had closed her womb. [6] Because the LORD had closed Hannah's womb, her rival would provoke her and taunt her viciously. [7] And this went on year after year. Whenever Hannah went up to the house of the LORD, her rival taunted her until she wept and would not eat. [8] "Hannah, why are you crying?" her husband Elkanah asked. "Why won't you eat? Why is your heart so grieved? Am I not better to you than ten sons?"

[9] So after they had finished eating and drinking in Shiloh, Hannah stood up. Now Eli the priest was sitting on a chair by the doorpost of the temple of the LORD. [10] In her bitter distress, Hannah prayed to the LORD and wept with many tears. [11] And she made a vow, pleading, "O LORD of Hosts, if only You will look upon the affliction of Your maidservant and remember me, not forgetting Your maidservant but giving her a son, then I will dedicate him to the LORD all the days of his life, and no razor shall ever come over his head." [12] As Hannah kept on praying before the LORD, Eli watched her mouth. [13] Hannah was praying in her heart, and though her lips were moving, her voice could not be heard. So Eli thought she was drunk

[14] and said to her, "How long will you be drunk? Put away your wine!" [15] "No, my lord," Hannah replied. "I am a woman oppressed in spirit. I have not had any wine or strong drink, but I have poured out my soul before the LORD." [16] "Do not take your servant for a wicked woman; for all this time I have been praying out of the depth of my anguish and grief." [17] "Go in peace," Eli replied, "and may the God of Israel grant the petition you have asked of Him."

[18] "May your maidservant find favor with you," said Hannah. Then she went on her way, and she began eating again, and her face was no longer downcast.

[19] The next morning Elkanah and Hannah got up early to bow in worship before the LORD, and then returned home to Ramah. And Elkanah had relations with his wife Hannah, and the LORD remembered her. [20] So in the course of time, Hannah conceived and gave birth to a son. She named him Samuel, saying, "Because I have asked for him from the LORD." [21] Then Elkanah and all his house went up to make the annual sacrifice to the LORD and to fulfill his vow, [22] but Hannah did not go. "After the boy is weaned," she said to her husband, "I will take him to appear before the LORD and to stay there permanently." [23] "Do what you think is best," her husband Elkanah replied, "and stay here until you have weaned him. Only may the LORD confirm His word." So Hannah stayed and nursed her son until she had weaned him. [24] Once she had weaned him, Hannah took the boy with her, along with a three-year-old bull, an ephah of flour, and a skin of wine. Though the boy was still young, she brought him to the house of the LORD at Shiloh. [25] And when they had slaughtered the bull, they brought the boy to Eli. [26] "Please, my lord," said Hannah, "as surely as you live, my lord, I am the woman who stood here beside you praying to the LORD." [27] I prayed for this boy, and since the LORD has granted me what I asked of Him, [28] "I now dedicate the boy to the LORD. For as long as he lives, he is dedicated to the LORD." So they worshiped the LORD there.

2 At that time Hannah prayed: "My heart rejoices in the LORD in whom my horn is exalted. My mouth speaks boldly against my enemies, for I rejoice in Your salvation." [2] There is no one holy like the LORD. Indeed, there is no one besides You! And there is no Rock like our God. [3] Do not boast so proudly, or let arrogance come from your mouth, for the LORD is a God who knows, and by Him actions are weighed. [4] The bows of the mighty are broken, but the feeble are equipped with strength. [5] The well-fed hire themselves out for food, but the starving hunger no more. The barren woman gives birth to seven, but she who has many sons pines away. [6] The LORD brings death and gives life; He brings down to Sheol and raises up. [7] The LORD sends poverty and wealth; He humbles and He exalts. [8] He raises the poor from the dust and lifts the needy from the ash heap. He seats them among princes and bestows on them a throne of honor. For the foundations of the earth are the LORD's, and upon them He has set the world. [9] He guards the steps of His faithful ones, but the wicked perish in darkness; for by his own strength shall no man prevail. [10] "Those who oppose the LORD will be shattered. He will thunder from heaven against them. The LORD will judge the ends of the earth and will give power to His king. He will exalt the horn of His anointed." [11] Then Elkanah went home to Ramah, but the boy began ministering to the LORD before Eli the priest.

[12] Now the sons of Eli were wicked men; they had no regard for the LORD [13] or for the custom of the priests with the people. When any man offered a sacrifice, the servant of the priest would come with a three-pronged meat fork while the meat was boiling [14] and plunge it into the pan or kettle or cauldron or cooking pot. And the priest would claim for himself whatever the meat fork brought up. This is how they treated all the Israelites who came to Shiloh. [15] Even before the fat was burned, the servant of the priest would come and say to the man who was sacrificing, "Give the priest some meat to roast, because he will not accept boiled meat from you, but only raw."

[16] And if any man said to him, "The fat must be burned first; then you may take whatever you want," the servant would reply, "No, you must give it to me right now. If you refuse, I will take it by force!" [17] Thus the sin of these young men was severe in the sight of the LORD, for they were treating the LORD's offering with contempt. [18] Now Samuel was ministering before the LORD—a boy wearing a linen ephod. [19] Each year his mother would make him a little robe and bring it to him when she went with her husband to offer the annual sacrifice. [20] And Eli would bless Elkanah and his wife, saying, "May the LORD give you children by this woman in place of the one she dedicated to the LORD." Then they would go home. [21] So the LORD attended to Hannah, and she conceived and gave birth to three sons and two daughters. Meanwhile, the boy Samuel grew up in the presence of the LORD. [22] Now Eli was very old, and he heard about everything his sons were doing to all Israel and how they were sleeping with the women who served at the entrance to the Tent of Meeting. [23] "Why are you doing these things?" Eli said to his sons. "I hear about your wicked deeds from all these people."

[24] No, my sons; it is not a good report I hear circulating among the LORD's people. [25] "If a man sins against another man, God can intercede for him; but if a man sins against the LORD, who can intercede for him?" But they would not listen to their father, since the LORD intended to put them to death. [26] And the boy Samuel continued to grow in stature and in favor with the LORD and with man. [27] Then a man of God came to Eli and told him, "This is what the LORD says: 'Did I not clearly reveal Myself to your father's house when they were in Egypt under Pharaoh's house?'" [28] And out of all the tribes of Israel I selected your father to be My priest, to offer sacrifices on My altar, to burn incense, and to wear an ephod in My presence. I also gave to the house of your father all the offerings of the Israelites made by fire. [29] Why then do you kick at My sacrifice and offering that I have prescribed for My dwelling place? You have honored your sons more than Me by fattening yourselves with the best of all the offerings of My people Israel.' [30] Therefore, the LORD, the God of Israel, declares: 'I did indeed say that your house and the house of your father would walk before Me forever. But now the LORD declares: Far be it from Me! For I will honor those who honor Me, but those who despise Me will be disdained.' [31] Behold, the days are coming when I will cut off your strength and the strength of your father's house, so that no older man will be left in your house. [32] You will see distress in My dwelling place. Despite all that is good in Israel, no one in your house will ever again reach old age. [33] And every one of you that I do not cut off from My altar, your eyes will fail and your heart will grieve. All your descendants will die by the sword of men. [34] And this sign shall come to you concerning your two sons Hophni and Phinehas: They will both die on the same day. [35] Then I will raise up for Myself a faithful priest. He will do whatever is in My heart and mind. And I will build for him an enduring house, and he will walk before My anointed one for all time. [36] "And everyone left in your house will come and bow down to him for a piece of silver or a morsel of bread, pleading, "Please appoint me to some priestly office so that I can eat a piece of bread.""

3 And the boy Samuel ministered to the LORD before Eli. Now in those days the word of the LORD was rare and visions were scarce. [2] And at that time Eli, whose eyesight had grown so dim that he could not see, was lying in his room. [3] Before the lamp of God had gone out, Samuel was lying down in the temple of the LORD, where the ark of God was located. [4] Then the LORD called to Samuel, and he answered, "Here I am." [5] He ran to Eli and said, "Here I am, for you have called me." "I did not call," Eli replied. "Go back and lie down." So he went and lay down. [6] Once again the LORD called, "Samuel!" So Samuel got up, went to Eli, and said, "Here I am, for you have called me." "My son, I did not call," Eli replied. "Go back and lie down."

[7] Now Samuel did not yet know the LORD, because the word of the LORD had not yet been revealed to him. [8] Once again, for the third time, the LORD called to Samuel. He got up, went to Eli, and said, "Here I am, for you have called me." Then Eli realized that it was the LORD who was calling the boy. [9] "Go and lie down," he said to Samuel, "and if He calls you, say, 'Speak, LORD, for Your servant is listening.'" So Samuel went and lay down in his place. [10] Then the LORD came and stood there, calling as before, "Samuel! Samuel!" And Samuel answered, "Speak, for Your servant is listening."

[11] Then the LORD said to Samuel, "I am about to do something in Israel at which the ears of all who hear it will tingle." [12] On that day I will carry out against Eli everything I have spoken about his family, from beginning to end. [13] I told him that I would judge his house forever for the iniquity of which he knows, because his sons blasphemed God and he did not restrain them.

[14] "Therefore I have sworn to the house of Eli, 'The iniquity of Eli's house shall never be atoned for by sacrifice or offering.'" [15] Samuel lay down until the morning; then he opened the doors of the house of the LORD. He was afraid to tell Eli the vision, [16] but Eli called to him and said, "Samuel, my son." "Here

I am," answered Samuel. [17] "What was the message He gave you?" Eli asked. "Do not hide it from me. May God punish you, and ever so severely, if you hide from me anything He said to you." [18] So Samuel told him everything and did not hide a thing from him. "He is the LORD," replied Eli. "Let Him do what is good in His eyes." [19] And Samuel grew, and the LORD was with him, and He let none of Samuel's words fall to the ground. [20] So all Israel from Dan to Beersheba knew that Samuel was confirmed as a prophet of the LORD. [21] And the LORD continued to appear at Shiloh, because there He revealed Himself to Samuel by His word.

4 Thus the word of Samuel came to all Israel. Now the Israelites went out to meet the Philistines in battle and camped at Ebenezer, while the Philistines camped at Aphek. [2] The Philistines arrayed themselves against Israel, and as the battle spread, Israel was defeated by the Philistines, who struck down about four thousand men on the battlefield. [3] When the troops returned to the camp, the elders of Israel asked, "Why has the LORD brought defeat on us before the Philistines today? Let us bring the ark of the covenant of the LORD from Shiloh, so that it may go with us to save us from the hand of our enemies." [4] So the people sent men to Shiloh, and they brought back the ark of the covenant of the LORD of Hosts, who sits enthroned between the cherubim. And the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, were there with the ark of the covenant of God. [5] When the ark of the covenant of the LORD entered the camp, all the Israelites raised such a great shout that it shook the ground. [6] On hearing the noise of the shout, the Philistines asked, "What is this loud shouting in the camp of the Hebrews?" And when they realized that the ark of the LORD had entered the camp, [7] the Philistines were afraid. "The gods have entered their camp!" they said. "Woe to us, for nothing like this has happened before." [8] Woe to us! Who will deliver us from the hand of these mighty gods? These are the gods who struck the Egyptians with all kinds of plagues in the wilderness. [9] "Take courage and be men, O Philistines! Otherwise, you will serve the Hebrews just as they served you. Now be men and fight!"

[10] So the Philistines fought, and Israel was defeated, and each man fled to his tent. The slaughter was very great—thirty thousand foot soldiers of Israel fell. [11] The ark of God was captured, and Eli's two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, died. [12] That same day a Benjamite ran from the battle line all the way to Shiloh, with his clothes torn and dirt on his head. [13] When he arrived, there was Eli, sitting on his chair beside the road and watching, because his heart trembled for the ark of God. When the man entered the city to give a report, the whole city cried out.

[14] Eli heard the outcry and asked, "Why this commotion?" So the man hurried over and reported to Eli. [15] Now Eli was ninety-eight years old, and his gaze was fixed because he could not see. [16] "I have just come from the battle," the man said to Eli. "I fled from there today." "What happened, my son?" Eli asked. [17] The messenger answered, "Israel has fled before the Philistines, and there has been a great slaughter among the people. Your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas, are both dead, and the ark of God has been captured." [18] As soon as the ark of God was mentioned, Eli fell backward from his chair by the city gate, and being old and heavy, he broke his neck and died. And Eli had judged Israel forty years. [19] Now Eli's daughter-in-law, the wife of Phinehas, was pregnant and about to give birth. When she heard the news of the capture of God's ark and the deaths of her father-in-law and her husband, she collapsed and gave birth, for her labor pains overtook her. [20] As she was dying, the women attending to her said, "Do not be afraid, for you have given birth to a son!" But she did not respond or pay any heed. [21] And she named the boy Ichabod, saying, "The glory has departed from Israel," because the ark of God had been captured and her father-in-law and her husband had been killed. [22] "The glory has departed from Israel," she said, "for the ark of God has been captured."

5 After the Philistines had captured the ark of God, they took it from Ebenezer to Ashdod, [2] carried it into the temple of Dagon, and set it beside his statue. [3] When the people of Ashdod got up early the next morning, there was Dagon, fallen on his face before the ark of the LORD. So they took Dagon and returned him to his place. [4] But when they got up early the next morning, there was Dagon, fallen on his face before the ark of the LORD, with his head and his hands broken off and lying on the threshold. Only the torso remained. [5] That is why, to this day, the priests of Dagon and all who enter the temple of Dagon in Ashdod do not step on the threshold. [6] Now the hand of the LORD was heavy on the people of Ashdod and its vicinity, ravaging them and afflicting them with tumors. [7] And when the men of Ashdod saw what was happening, they said, "The ark of the God of Israel must not stay here with us, because His hand is heavy upon us and upon our god Dagon." [8] So they called together all the rulers of the Philistines and asked, "What shall we do with the ark of the God of Israel?" "It must be moved to Gath," they replied. So they carried away the ark of the God of Israel. [9] But after they had moved the ark to Gath, the LORD's hand was also against that city, throwing it into great confusion and afflicting the men of the city, both young and old, with an outbreak of tumors. [10] So they sent the ark of God to Ekron, but as it arrived, the Ekronites cried out, "They have brought us the ark of the God of Israel in order to kill us and our people!" [11] Then the Ekronites assembled all the rulers of the Philistines and said, "Send away the ark of the God of Israel. It must return to its place, so that it will not kill us and our people!" For a deadly confusion had pervaded the city; the hand of God was heavy upon it. [12] Those who did not die were afflicted with tumors, and the outcry of the city went up to heaven.

6 When the ark of the LORD had been in the land of the Philistines seven months, [2] the Philistines summoned the priests and diviners, saying, "What shall we do with the ark of the LORD? Tell us how to send it back to its place." [3] They replied, "If you return the ark of the God of Israel, do not send it away empty, but by all means return it to Him with a guilt offering. Then you will be healed, and you will understand why His hand has not been lifted from you." [4] "What guilt offering should we send back to Him?" asked the Philistines. "Five gold tumors and five gold rats," they said, "according to the number of rulers of the Philistines, since the same plague has struck both you and your rulers." [5] Make images of your tumors and of the rats that are ravaging the land. Give glory to the God of Israel, and perhaps He will lift His hand from you and your gods and your land. [6] Why harden your hearts as the Egyptians and Pharaoh hardened theirs? When He afflicted them, did they not send the people on their way as they departed?

[7] Now, therefore, prepare one new cart with two milk cows that have never been yoked. Hitch the cows to the cart, but take their calves away and pen them up. [8] Take the ark of the LORD, set it on the cart, and in a chest beside it put the gold objects you are sending Him as a guilt offering. Then send the ark on its way, [9] "but keep watching it. If it goes up the road to its homeland, toward Beth-shemesh, it is the LORD who has brought on us this great disaster. But if it does not, then we will know that it was not His hand that punished us and that it happened by chance."

[10] So the men did as instructed. They took two milk cows, hitched them to the cart, and penned up their calves. [11] Then they put the ark of the LORD on the cart, along with the chest containing the gold rats and the images of the tumors. [12] And the cows headed straight up the road toward Beth-shemesh, staying on that one highway and lowing as they went, never straying to the right or to the left. The rulers of the Philistines followed behind them to the border of Beth-shemesh. [13] Now the people of Beth-shemesh were harvesting wheat in the valley, and when they looked up and saw the ark, they were overjoyed at the sight.

[14] The cart came to the field of Joshua of Beth-shemesh and stopped there near a large rock. The people chopped up the cart and offered the cows as a burnt offering to the LORD. [15] And the Levites took down the ark of the LORD and the chest containing the gold objects, and they placed them on the large rock. That day the men of Beth-shemesh offered burnt offerings and made sacrifices to the LORD. [16] And when the five rulers of the Philistines saw this, they returned to Ekron that same day. [17] As a guilt offering to the LORD, the Philistines had sent back one gold tumor for each city: Ashdod, Gaza, Ashkelon, Gath, and Ekron. [18] The number of gold rats also corresponded to the number of Philistine cities belonging to the five rulers—the fortified cities and their outlying villages. And the large rock on which they placed the ark of the LORD stands to this day in the field of Joshua of Beth-shemesh. [19] But God struck down some of the people of Beth-shemesh because they looked inside the ark of the LORD. He struck down seventy men, and the people mourned because the LORD had struck them with a great slaughter. [20] The men of Beth-shemesh asked, "Who can stand in the presence of the LORD, this holy God? To whom should the ark go up from here?" [21] So they sent messengers to the people of Kiriath-jearim, saying, "The Philistines have returned the ark of the LORD. Come down and take it up with you."

7 Then the men of Kiriath-jearim came for the ark of the LORD and took it into Abinadab's house on the hill. And they consecrated his son Eleazar to guard the ark of the LORD. [2] And from that day a long time passed, twenty years in all, as the ark remained at Kiriath-jearim. And all the house of Israel mourned and sought after the LORD. [3] Then Samuel said to all the house of Israel, "If you are returning to the LORD with all your hearts, then rid yourselves of the foreign gods and Ashtoreths among you, prepare your hearts for the LORD, and serve Him only. And He will deliver you from the hand of the Philistines." [4] So the Israelites put away the Baals and Ashtoreths and served only the LORD. [5] Then Samuel said, "Gather all Israel to Mizpah, and I will pray to the LORD on your behalf." [6] When they had gathered at Mizpah, they drew water and poured it out before the LORD. On that day they fasted, and there they confessed, "We have sinned against the LORD." And Samuel judged the Israelites at Mizpah. [7] When the Philistines heard that the Israelites had gathered at Mizpah, their rulers marched up toward Israel. And when the Israelites learned of this, they feared the Philistines

[8] and said to Samuel, "Do not stop crying out to the LORD our God for us, that He may save us from the hand of the Philistines." [9] Then Samuel took a suckling lamb and offered it as a whole burnt offering to the LORD. He cried out to the LORD on behalf of Israel, and the LORD answered him. [10] As the Philistines drew near to fight against Israel, Samuel was sacrificing the burnt offering. But that day the LORD thundered loudly against the Philistines and threw them into such confusion that they fled before Israel. [11] Then the men of Israel charged out of Mizpah and pursued the Philistines, striking them down all the way to an area below Beth-car. [12] Afterward, Samuel took a stone and set it up between Mizpah and Shen. He named it Ebenezer, saying, "Thus far the LORD has helped us." [13] So the Philistines were subdued, and they stopped invading the territory of Israel. And the hand of the LORD was against the Philistines

all the days of Samuel. [14] The cities from Ekron to Gath, which the Philistines had taken, were restored to Israel, who also delivered the surrounding territory from the hand of the Philistines. And there was peace between the Israelites and the Amorites. [15] So Samuel judged Israel all the days of his life. [16] Every year he would go on a circuit from Bethel to Gilgal to Mizpah, judging Israel in all these places. [17] Then he would return to Ramah because his home was there, and there he judged Israel and built an altar to the LORD.

8 When Samuel grew old, he appointed his sons as judges over Israel. [2] The name of his firstborn son was Joel, and the name of his second was Abijah. They were judges in Beersheba. [3] But his sons did not walk in his ways; they turned aside toward dishonest gain, accepting bribes and perverting justice. [4] So all the elders of Israel gathered together and came to Samuel at Ramah. [5] "Look," they said, "you are old, and your sons do not walk in your ways. Now appoint a king to judge us like all the other nations." [6] But when they said, "Give us a king to judge us," their demand was displeasing in the sight of Samuel; so he prayed to the LORD.

[7] And the LORD said to Samuel, "Listen to the voice of the people in all that they say to you. For it is not you they have rejected, but they have rejected Me as their king." [8] Just as they have done from the day I brought them up out of Egypt until this day, forsaking Me and serving other gods, so they are doing to you. [9] "Now listen to them, but you must solemnly warn them and show them the manner of the king who will reign over them."

[10] So Samuel spoke all the words of the LORD to the people who were asking him for a king. [11] He said, "This will be the manner of the king who will reign over you: He will take your sons and appoint them to his own chariots and horses, to run in front of his chariots." [12] He will appoint some for himself as commanders of thousands and of fifties, and others to plow his ground, to reap his harvest, to make his weapons of war, and to equip his chariots. [13] And he will take your daughters to be perfumers, cooks, and bakers.

[14] He will take the best of your fields and vineyards and olive groves and give them to his servants. [15] He will take a tenth of your grain and grape harvest and give it to his officials and servants. [16] And he will take your menservants and maidservants and your best cattle and donkeys and put them to his own use. [17] He will take a tenth of your flocks, and you yourselves will become his slaves. [18] "When that day comes, you will beg for relief from the king you have chosen, but the LORD will not answer you on that day." [19] Nevertheless, the people refused to listen to Samuel. "No!" they said. "We must have a king over us." [20] "Then we will be like all the other nations, with a king to judge us, to go out before us, and to fight our battles." [21] Samuel listened to all the words of the people and repeated them in the hearing of the LORD. [22] "Listen to their voice," the LORD said to Samuel. "Appoint a king for them." Then Samuel told the men of Israel, "Everyone must go back to his city."

9 Now there was a Benjamite, a powerful man, whose name was Kish son of Abiel, the son of Zeror, the son of Becorath, the son of Aphiah of Benjamin. [2] And he had a son named Saul, choice and handsome, without equal among the Israelites—a head taller than any of the people. [3] One day the donkeys of Saul's father Kish wandered off, and Kish said to his son Saul, "Take one of the servants and go look for the donkeys." [4] So Saul passed through the hill country of Ephraim and then through the land of Shalishah, but did not find the donkeys. He and the servant went through the region of Shaalim, but they were not there. Then they went through the land of Benjamin, and still they did not find them. [5] When they reached the land of Zuph, Saul said to his servant, "Come, let us go back, or my father will stop worrying about the donkeys and start worrying about us." [6] "Look," said the servant, "in this city there is a man of God who is highly respected; everything he says surely comes to pass. Let us go there now. Perhaps he will tell us which way to go." [7] "If we do go," Saul replied, "what can we give the man? For the bread in our packs is gone, and there is no gift to take to the man of God. What do we have?" [8] The servant answered him again. "Look," he said, "I have here in my hand a quarter shekel of silver. I will give it to the man of God, and he will tell us our way."

[9] (Formerly in Israel, a man on his way to inquire of God would say, "Come, let us go to the seer." For the prophet of today was formerly called the seer.) [10] "Good," said Saul to his servant. "Come, let us go." So they set out for the city where the man of God was. [11] And as they were climbing the hill to the city, they met some young women coming out to draw water and asked, "Is the seer here?"

[12] "Yes, he is ahead of you," they answered. "Hurry now, for today he has come to the city because the people have a sacrifice on the high place." [13] "As soon as you enter the city, you will find him before he goes up to the high place to eat. The people will not eat until he comes, because he must bless the sacrifice; after that, the guests will eat. Go up at once; you will find him." [14] So Saul and his servant went up toward the city, and as they were entering it, there was Samuel coming toward them on his way up to the high place. [15] Now on the day before Saul's arrival, the LORD had revealed to Samuel, [16] "At this time tomorrow I will send you a man from the land of Benjamin, and you are to anoint him leader over My people Israel; he will save them from the hand of the Philistines. For I have looked upon My people, because their cry has come to Me." [17] When Samuel saw Saul, the LORD told him, "Here is the man of whom I spoke; he shall rule over My people."

[18] Saul approached Samuel in the gateway and asked, "Would you please tell me where the seer's house is?" [19] "I am the seer," Samuel replied. "Go up before me to the high place, for you shall eat with me today. And when I send you off in the morning, I will tell you all that is in your heart." [20] "As for the donkeys you lost three days ago, do not worry about them, for they have been found. And upon whom is all the desire of Israel, if not upon you and all your father's house?" [21] Saul replied, "Am I not a Benjamite from the smallest tribe of Israel, and is not my clan the least of all the clans of Benjamin? So why would you say such a thing to me?" [22] Then Samuel took Saul and his servant, brought them into the hall, and seated them in the place of honor among those who were invited—about thirty in all. [23] And Samuel said to the cook, "Bring the portion I gave you and told you to set aside." [24] So the cook picked up the leg and what was attached to it and set it before Saul. Then Samuel said, "Here is what was kept back. It was set apart for you. Eat, for it has been kept for you for this occasion, from the time I said, 'I have invited the people.'" So Saul dined with Samuel that day. [25] And after they had come down from the high place into the city, Samuel spoke with Saul on the roof of his house. [26] They got up early in the morning, and just before dawn Samuel called to Saul on the roof, "Get ready, and I will send you on your way!" So Saul arose, and both he and Samuel went outside together. [27] As they were going down to the edge of the city, Samuel said to Saul, "Tell the servant to go on ahead of us, but you stay for a while, and I will reveal to you the word of God." So the servant went on.

10 Then Samuel took a flask of oil, poured it on Saul's head, kissed him, and said, "Has not the LORD anointed you ruler over His inheritance?" [2] When you leave me today, you will find two men at Rachel's tomb in Zelzah on the border of Benjamin. They will say to you, 'The donkeys you seek have been found, and now your father has stopped worrying about the donkeys and started worrying about you, asking, "What should I do about my son?"' [3] Then you will go on from there until you come to the Oak of Tabor. Three men going up to God at Bethel will meet you there, one carrying three young goats, another carrying three loaves of bread, and another carrying a skin of wine. [4] They will greet you and give you two loaves of bread, which you will accept from their hands. [5] After that you will come to Gibeah of God, where the Philistines have an outpost. As you approach the city, you will meet a group of prophets coming down from the high place, preceded by harps, tambourines, flutes, and lyres, and they will be prophesying. [6] Then the Spirit of the LORD will rush upon you, and you will prophesy with them; and you will be transformed into a different person. [7] When these signs have come, do as the occasion demands, for God is with you. [8] "And you shall go before me to Gilgal, and surely I will come to you to offer burnt offerings and to sacrifice peace offerings. Wait seven days until I come to you and show you what you are to do."

[9] As Saul turned to leave Samuel, God changed Saul's heart, and all the signs came to pass that day. [10] When Saul and his servant arrived at Gibeah, a group of prophets met him. Then the Spirit of God rushed upon him, and he prophesied along with them. [11] All those who had formerly known Saul and saw him prophesying with the prophets asked one another, "What has happened to the son of Kish? Is Saul also among the prophets?" [12] Then a man who lived there replied, "And who is their father?" So the saying became a proverb: "Is Saul also among the prophets?" [13] And when Saul had finished prophesying, he went up to the high place. [14] Now Saul's uncle asked him and his servant, "Where did you go?" "To look for the donkeys," Saul replied. "When we saw they were not to be found, we went to Samuel."

[15] "Tell me," Saul's uncle asked, "what did Samuel say to you?" [16] And Saul replied, "He assured us that the donkeys had been found." But Saul did not tell his uncle what Samuel had said about the kingship. [17] After this, Samuel summoned the people to the LORD at Mizpah

[18] and said to the Israelites, "This is what the LORD, the God of Israel, says: 'I brought Israel up out of Egypt, and I rescued you from the hands of the Egyptians and of all the kingdoms that oppressed you.'" [19] "But today you have rejected your God, who saves you from all your troubles and afflictions, and you have said to Him, 'No, set a king over us.' Now therefore present yourselves before the LORD by your tribes and clans." [20] Thus Samuel had all the tribes of Israel come forward, and the tribe of Benjamin was selected. [21] Then he had the tribe of Benjamin come forward by its clans, and the clan of Matri was selected. Finally, Saul son of Kish was selected. But when they looked for him, they could not find him. [22] So again they inquired of the LORD, "Has the man come here yet?" And the LORD replied, "Behold, he has hidden himself among the baggage." [23] So they ran and brought Saul, and when he stood among the people, he was a head taller than any of the others. [24] Samuel said to all the people, "Do you see the one the LORD has chosen? There is no one like him among all the people." And all the people shouted, "Long live the king!" [25] Then Samuel explained to the people the rights of kingship. He wrote them on a scroll and laid it up before the LORD. And Samuel sent all the people away, each to his own home. [26] Saul also went to his home in Gibeah, and the men of valor whose hearts God had touched went with him. [27] But some worthless men said, "How can this man save us?" So they despised him and brought him no gifts; but Saul remained silent about it.

11 Soon Nahash the Ammonite came up and laid siege to Jabesh-gilead. All the men of Jabesh said to him, "Make a treaty with us, and we will serve you." [2] But Nahash the Ammonite replied, "I will make a treaty with you on one

condition, that I may put out everyone's right eye and bring reproach upon all Israel." [3] "Hold off for seven days," replied the elders of Jabesh, "and let us send messengers throughout Israel. If there is no one to save us, we will surrender to you." [4] When the messengers came to Gibeah of Saul and relayed these words in the hearing of the people, they all wept aloud. [5] Just then Saul was returning from the field, behind his oxen. "What troubles the people?" asked Saul. "Why are they weeping?" And they relayed to him the words of the men from Jabesh. [6] When Saul heard their words, the Spirit of God rushed upon him, and he burned with great anger. [7] He took a pair of oxen, cut them into pieces, and sent them by messengers throughout the land of Israel, proclaiming, "This is what will be done to the oxen of anyone who does not march behind Saul and Samuel." Then the terror of the LORD fell upon the people, and they turned out as one man.

[8] And when Saul numbered them at Bezek, there were 300,000 Israelites and 30,000 men of Judah. [9] So they said to the messengers who had come, "Tell the men of Jabesh-gilead: 'Deliverance will be yours tomorrow by the time the sun is hot.'" And when the messengers relayed this to the men of Jabesh, they rejoiced. [10] Then the men of Jabesh said to Nahash, "Tomorrow we will come out, and you can do with us whatever seems good to you." [11] The next day Saul organized the troops into three divisions, and during the morning watch they invaded the camp of the Ammonites and slaughtered them, until the hottest part of the day. And the survivors were so scattered that no two of them were left together. [12] Then the people said to Samuel, "Who said that Saul should not reign over us? Bring those men here so we can kill them!" [13] But Saul ordered, "No one shall be put to death this day, for today the LORD has worked salvation in Israel." [14] Then Samuel said to the people, "Come, let us go to Gilgal and renew the kingship there." [15] So all the people went to Gilgal and confirmed Saul as king in the presence of the LORD. There they sacrificed peace offerings before the LORD, and Saul and all the Israelites rejoiced greatly.

12 Then Samuel said to all Israel, "I have listened to your voice in all that you have said to me, and I have set over you a king." [2] Now here is the king walking before you, and I am old and gray, and my sons are here with you. I have walked before you from my youth until this day. [3] "Here I am. Bear witness against me before the LORD and before His anointed: Whose ox or donkey have I taken? Whom have I cheated or oppressed? From whose hand have I accepted a bribe and closed my eyes? Tell me, and I will restore it to you." [4] "You have not wronged us or oppressed us," they replied, "nor have you taken anything from the hand of man." [5] Samuel said to them, "The LORD is a witness against you, and His anointed is a witness today, that you have not found anything in my hand." "He is a witness," they replied. [6] Then Samuel said to the people, "The LORD is the One who appointed Moses and Aaron, and who brought your fathers up out of the land of Egypt." [7] Now present yourselves, so that I may confront you before the LORD with all the righteous acts He has done for you and your fathers.

[8] When Jacob went to Egypt, your fathers cried out to the LORD, and He sent them Moses and Aaron, who brought your fathers out of Egypt and settled them in this place. [9] But they forgot the LORD their God, and He sold them into the hand of Sisera the commander of the army of Hazor, and into the hands of the Philistines and the king of Moab, who fought against them. [10] Then they cried out to the LORD and said, 'We have sinned, for we have forsaken the LORD and served the Baals and Ashtoreths. Now deliver us from the hands of our enemies, that we may serve You.'

[11] So the LORD sent Jerubbaal, Barak, Jephthah, and Samuel, and He delivered you from the hands of your enemies on every side, and you dwelt securely. [12] But when you saw that Nahash king of the Ammonites was moving against you, you said to me, 'No, we must have a king to rule over us'—even though the LORD your God was your king. [13] Now here is the king you have chosen, the one you requested. Behold, the LORD has placed a king over you. [14] If you fear the LORD and serve Him and obey His voice, and if you do not rebel against the command of the LORD, and if both you and the king who reigns over you follow the LORD your God, then all will be well. [15] But if you disobey the LORD and rebel against His command, then the hand of the LORD will be against you as it was against your fathers.

[16] Now, therefore, stand and see this great thing that the LORD will do before your eyes. [17] "Is it not the wheat harvest today? I will call on the LORD to send thunder and rain, so that you will know and see what a great evil you have committed in the sight of the LORD by asking for a king." [18] So Samuel called to the LORD, and on that day the LORD sent thunder and rain. As a result, all the people greatly feared the LORD and Samuel. [19] They pleaded with Samuel, "Pray to the LORD your God for your servants so that we will not die! For we have added to all our sins the evil of asking for a king." [20] "Do not be afraid," Samuel replied. "Even though you have committed all this evil, do not turn aside from following the LORD, but serve the LORD with all your heart." [21] Do not turn aside after worthless things that cannot profit you or deliver you, for they are empty. [22] Indeed, for the sake of His great name, the LORD will not abandon His people, because He was pleased to make you His own. [23] As for me, far be it from me that I should sin against the LORD by ceasing to pray for you. And I will continue to teach you the good and right way. [24] Above all, fear the LORD and serve Him faithfully with all your heart; consider what great things He has done for you. [25] "But if you persist in doing evil, both you and your king will be swept away."

13 Saul was thirty years old when he became king, and he reigned over Israel forty-two years. [2] He chose for himself three thousand men of Israel: Two thousand were with Saul at Michmash and in the hill country of Bethel, and a thousand were with Jonathan in Gibeah of Benjamin. And the rest of the troops he sent away, each to his own home. [3] Then Jonathan attacked the Philistine outpost at Geba, and the Philistines heard about it. So Saul blew the ram's horn throughout the land, saying, "Let the Hebrews hear!" [4] And all Israel heard the news: "Saul has attacked an outpost of the Philistines, and now Israel has become a stench to the Philistines!" Then the people were summoned to join Saul at Gilgal. [5] Now the Philistines assembled to fight against Israel with three thousand chariots, six thousand horsemen, and troops as numerous as the sand on the seashore. They went up and camped at Michmash, east of Beth-aven. [6] Seeing that they were in danger because their troops were hard-pressed, the men of Israel hid in caves and thickets, among the rocks, and in cellars and cisterns.

[7] Some Hebrews even crossed the Jordan into the land of Gad and Gilead. Saul, however, remained at Gilgal, and all his troops were quaking in fear. [8] And Saul waited seven days for the time appointed by Samuel, but Samuel did not come to Gilgal, and the troops began to desert Saul. [9] So he said, "Bring me the burnt offering and the peace offerings." And he offered up the burnt offering. [10] Just as he finished offering the burnt offering, Samuel arrived, and Saul went out to greet him.

[11] "What have you done?" Samuel asked. And Saul replied, "When I saw that the troops were deserting me, and that you did not come at the appointed time and the Philistines were gathering at Michmash," [12] "I thought, 'Now the Philistines will descend upon me at Gilgal, and I have not sought the favor of the LORD.' So I felt compelled to offer the burnt offering." [13] "You have acted foolishly," Samuel declared. "You have not kept the command that the LORD your God gave you; if you had, the LORD would have established your kingdom over Israel for all time." [14] "But now your kingdom will not endure; the LORD has sought a man after His own heart and appointed him ruler over His people, because you have not kept the command of the LORD."

[15] Then Samuel set out from Gilgal and went up to Gibeah in Benjamin. And Saul numbered the troops who were with him, about six hundred men. [16] Now Saul and Jonathan his son and the troops with them were staying in Geba of Benjamin, while the Philistines camped at Michmash. [17] And raiders went out of the Philistine camp in three divisions. One headed toward Ophrah in the land of Shual, [18] another toward Beth-horon, and the third down the border road overlooking the Valley of Zeboim facing the wilderness. [19] And no blacksmith could be found in all the land of Israel, because the Philistines had said, "The Hebrews must not be allowed to make swords or spears." [20] Instead, all the Israelites would go down to the Philistines to sharpen their plowshares, mattocks, axes, and sickles. [21] The charge was a pim for sharpening a plowshare or mattock, a third of a shekel for sharpening a pitchfork or an axe, and a third of a shekel for repointing an oxgoad. [22] So on the day of battle not a sword or spear could be found in the hands of the troops with Saul and Jonathan; only Saul and his son Jonathan had weapons. [23] And a garrison of the Philistines had gone out to the pass at Michmash.

14 One day Jonathan son of Saul said to the young man bearing his armor, "Come, let us cross over to the Philistine outpost on the other side." But Jonathan did not tell his father. [2] Meanwhile, Saul was staying under the pomegranate tree in Migron on the outskirts of Gibeah. And the troops who were with him numbered about six hundred men, [3] including Ahijah, who was wearing an ephod. He was the son of Ichabod's brother Ahitub son of Phinehas, the son of Eli the priest of the LORD in Shiloh. But the troops did not know that Jonathan had left. [4] Now there were cliffs on both sides of the pass that Jonathan intended to cross to reach the Philistine outpost. One was named Bozez and the other Seneh. [5] One cliff stood to the north toward Michmash, and the other to the south toward Geba. [6] Jonathan said to the young man bearing his armor, "Come, let us cross over to the outpost of these uncircumcised men. Perhaps the LORD will work on our behalf. Nothing can hinder the LORD from saving, whether by many or by few." [7] His armor-bearer replied, "Do all that is in your heart. Go ahead; I am with you heart and soul." [8] "Very well," said Jonathan, "we will cross over toward these men and show ourselves to them." [9] If they say, 'Wait until we come to you,' then we will stay where we are and will not go up to them. [10] "But if they say, 'Come on up,' then we will go up, because this will be our sign that the LORD has delivered them into our hands." [11] So the two of them showed themselves to the outpost of the Philistines, who exclaimed, "Look, the Hebrews are coming out of the holes in which they were hiding!" [12] So the men of the outpost called out to Jonathan and his armor-bearer, "Come on up, and we will teach you a lesson!" "Follow me," Jonathan told his armor-bearer, "for the LORD has delivered them into the hand of Israel." [13] So Jonathan climbed up on his hands and feet, with his armor-bearer behind him. And the Philistines fell before Jonathan, and his armor-bearer followed and finished them off. [14] In that first assault, Jonathan and his armor-bearer struck down about twenty men over half an acre of land. [15] Then terror struck the Philistines in the camp, in the field, and among all the people. Even those in the outposts and raiding parties trembled. Indeed, the earth quaked and panic spread from God. [16] Now when Saul's watchmen at Gibeah in Benjamin looked and saw the troops melting away and scattering in every direction, [17] Saul said to the troops who were with him, "Call the roll and see who has left us." And when they had called the roll, they saw

that Jonathan and his armor-bearer were not there. [18] Then Saul said to Ahijah, "Bring the ark of God." (For at that time it was with the Israelites.) [19] While Saul was talking to the priest, the commotion in the Philistine camp continued to increase. So Saul said to the priest, "Withdraw your hand." [20] Then Saul and all his troops assembled and marched to the battle, and they found the Philistines in total confusion, with each man wielding the sword against his neighbor. [21] And the Hebrews who had previously gone up into the surrounding camps of the Philistines now went over to the Israelites who were with Saul and Jonathan. [22] When all the Israelites who had been hiding in the hill country of Ephraim heard that the Philistines were fleeing, they also joined Saul and Jonathan in the battle.

[23] So the LORD saved Israel that day, and the battle moved on beyond Beth-aven. [24] Now the men of Israel were in distress that day, for Saul had placed the troops under an oath, saying, "Cursed is the man who eats any food before evening, before I have taken vengeance on my enemies." So none of the troops tasted any food. [25] Then all the troops entered the forest, and there was honey on the ground. [26] And when they entered the forest and saw the flowing honey, not one of them put his hand to his mouth, because they feared the oath. [27] Jonathan, however, had not heard that his father had charged the people with the oath. So he reached out the end of the staff in his hand, dipped it into the honeycomb, and put his hand to his mouth; and his eyes brightened. [28] Then one of the soldiers told him, "Your father bound the troops with a solemn oath, saying, 'Cursed is the man who eats food today.' That is why the people are faint." [29] "My father has brought trouble to the land," Jonathan replied. "Just look at how my eyes have brightened because I tasted a little of this honey." [30] "How much better it would have been if the troops had eaten freely today from the plunder they took from their enemies! Would not the slaughter of the Philistines have been much greater?" [31] That day, after the Israelites had struck down the Philistines from Michmash to Aijalon, the people were very faint. [32] So they rushed greedily to the plunder, taking sheep, cattle, and calves. They slaughtered them on the ground and ate meat with the blood still in it. [33] Then someone reported to Saul: "Look, the troops are sinning against the LORD by eating meat with the blood still in it." "You have broken faith," said Saul. "Roll a large stone over here at once."

[34] Then he said, "Go among the troops and tell them, 'Each man must bring me his ox or his sheep, slaughter them in this place, and then eat. Do not sin against the LORD by eating meat with the blood still in it.'" So that night everyone brought his ox and slaughtered it there. [35] Then Saul built an altar to the LORD; it was the first time he had built an altar to the LORD. [36] And Saul said, "Let us go down after the Philistines by night and plunder them until dawn, leaving no man alive!" "Do what seems good to you," the troops replied. But the priest said, "We must consult God here." [37] So Saul inquired of God, "Shall I go down after the Philistines? Will You give them into the hand of Israel?" But God did not answer him that day. [38] Therefore Saul said, "Come here, all you leaders of the troops, and let us investigate how this sin has occurred today." [39] "As surely as the LORD who saves Israel lives, even if it is my son Jonathan, he must die!" But not one of the troops said a word. [40] Then Saul said to all Israel, "You stand on one side, and I and my son Jonathan will stand on the other side." "Do what seems good to you," the troops replied. [41] So Saul said to the LORD, the God of Israel, "Why have You not answered Your servant this day? If the fault is with me or my son Jonathan, respond with Urim; but if the fault is with the men of Israel, respond with Thummim." And Jonathan and Saul were selected, but the people were cleared of the charge. [42] Then Saul said, "Cast the lot between me and my son Jonathan." And Jonathan was selected. [43] "Tell me what you have done," Saul commanded him. So Jonathan told him, "I only tasted a little honey with the end of the staff that was in my hand. And now I must die?" [44] And Saul declared, "May God punish me, and ever so severely, if you, Jonathan, do not surely die!" [45] But the people said to Saul, "Must Jonathan die—he who accomplished such a great deliverance for Israel? Never! As surely as the LORD lives, not a hair of his head will fall to the ground, for with God's help he has accomplished this today." So the people rescued Jonathan, and he did not die. [46] Then Saul gave up his pursuit of the Philistines, and the Philistines returned to their own land. [47] After Saul had assumed the kingship over Israel, he fought against all his enemies on every side—the Moabites, the Ammonites, the Edomites, the kings of Zobah, and the Philistines. Wherever he turned, he routed them. [48] He fought valiantly and defeated the Amalekites, delivering Israel from the hands of its plunderers. [49] Now the sons of Saul were Jonathan, Ishvi, and Malchishua. His two daughters were named Merab (his firstborn) and Michal (his younger daughter). [50] His wife's name was Ahinoam daughter of Ahimaaz. The name of the commander of his army was Abner, the son of Saul's uncle Ner. [51] Saul's father Kish and Abner's father Ner were sons of Abiel. [52] And the war with the Philistines was fierce for all the days of Saul. So whenever he noticed any strong or brave man, Saul would enlist him.

15 Then Samuel said to Saul, "The LORD sent me to anoint you king over His people Israel. Now therefore, listen to the words of the LORD." [2] This is what the LORD of Hosts says: 'I witnessed what the Amalekites did to the Israelites when they ambushed them on their way up from Egypt.' [3] "Now go and attack the Amalekites and devote to destruction all that belongs to them. Do not spare them, but put to death men and women, children and infants, oxen and sheep, camels and donkeys.'" [4] So Saul summoned the troops and numbered them at Telaim—200,000 foot soldiers and 10,000 men of Judah. [5] Saul came to the city of Amalek and lay in wait in the valley. [6] And he warned the Kenites, "Since you showed kindness to all the Israelites when they came up out of Egypt, go on and get away from the Amalekites. Otherwise I will sweep you away with them." So the Kenites moved away from the Amalekites. [7] Then Saul struck down the Amalekites all the way from Havilah to Shur, which is east of Egypt. [8] He captured Agag king of Amalek alive, but devoted all the others to destruction with the sword. [9] Saul and his troops spared Agag, along with the best of the sheep and cattle, the fat calves and lambs, and the best of everything else. They were unwilling to destroy them, but they devoted to destruction all that was despised and worthless. [10] Then the word of the LORD came to Samuel, saying, [11] "I regret that I have made Saul king, for he has turned away from following Me and has not carried out My instructions." And Samuel was distressed and cried out to the LORD all that night. [12] Early in the morning Samuel got up to confront Saul, but he was told, "Saul has gone to Carmel, and behold, he has set up a monument for himself and has turned and gone down to Gilgal." [13] When Samuel reached him, Saul said to him, "May the LORD bless you. I have carried out the LORD's instructions." [14] But Samuel replied, "Then what is this bleating of sheep and lowing of cattle that I hear?" [15] Saul answered, "The troops brought them from the Amalekites; they spared the best sheep and cattle to sacrifice to the LORD your God, but the rest we devoted to destruction."

[16] "Stop!" exclaimed Samuel. "Let me tell you what the LORD said to me last night." "Tell me," Saul replied. [17] And Samuel said, "Although you were once small in your own eyes, have you not become the head of the tribes of Israel? The LORD anointed you king over Israel" [18] and sent you on a mission, saying, 'Go and devote to destruction the sinful Amalekites. Fight against them until you have wiped them out.' [19] "So why did you not obey the LORD? Why did you rush upon the plunder and do evil in the sight of the LORD?" [20] "But I did obey the LORD," Saul replied. "I went on the mission that the LORD gave me. I brought back Agag king of Amalek and devoted the Amalekites to destruction." [21] "The troops took sheep and cattle from the plunder, the best of the things devoted to destruction, in order to sacrifice them to the LORD your God at Gilgal." [22] But Samuel declared: "Does the LORD delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices as much as in obedience to His voice? Behold, obedience is better than sacrifice, and attentiveness is better than the fat of rams."

[23] "For rebellion is like the sin of divination, and arrogance is like the wickedness of idolatry. Because you have rejected the word of the LORD, He has rejected you as king." [24] Then Saul said to Samuel, "I have sinned; I have transgressed the LORD's commandment and your instructions, because I feared the people and obeyed their voice." [25] "Now therefore, please forgive my sin and return with me so I can worship the LORD." [26] "I will not return with you," Samuel replied. "For you have rejected the word of the LORD, and He has rejected you as king over Israel." [27] As Samuel turned to go, Saul grabbed the hem of his robe, and it tore. [28] So Samuel said to him, "The LORD has torn the kingdom of Israel from you today and has given it to your neighbor who is better than you." [29] "Moreover, the Glory of Israel does not lie or change His mind, for He is not a man, that He should change His mind." [30] "I have sinned," Saul replied. "Please honor me now before the elders of my people and before Israel. Come back with me, so that I may worship the LORD your God." [31] So Samuel went back with Saul, and Saul worshiped the LORD. [32] Then Samuel said, "Bring me Agag king of the Amalekites." Agag came to him cheerfully, for he thought, "Surely the bitterness of death is past." [33] But Samuel declared: "As your sword has made women childless, so your mother will be childless among women." And Samuel hacked Agag to pieces before the LORD at Gilgal. [34] Then Samuel went to Ramah, but Saul went up to his home in Gibeah of Saul. [35] And to the day of his death, Samuel never again visited Saul. Samuel mourned for Saul, and the LORD regretted that He had made Saul king over Israel.

16 Now the LORD said to Samuel, "How long are you going to mourn for Saul, since I have rejected him as king over Israel? Fill your horn with oil and go. I am sending you to Jesse of Bethlehem, for I have selected from his sons a king for Myself." [2] "How can I go?" Samuel asked. "Saul will hear of it and kill me!" The LORD answered, "Take a heifer with you and say, 'I have come to sacrifice to the LORD.'" [3] "Then invite Jesse to the sacrifice, and I will show you what you are to do. You are to anoint for Me the one I indicate." [4] So Samuel did what the LORD had said and went to Bethlehem. When the elders of the town met him, they trembled and asked, "Do you come in peace?" [5] "In peace," he replied. "I have come to sacrifice to the LORD. Consecrate yourselves and come with me to the sacrifice." Then he consecrated Jesse and his sons and invited them to the sacrifice. [6] When they arrived, Samuel saw Eliab and said, "Surely here before the LORD is His anointed."

[7] But the LORD said to Samuel, "Do not consider his appearance or height, for I have rejected him; the LORD does not see as man does. For man sees the outward appearance, but the LORD sees the heart." [8] Then Jesse called Abinadab and presented him to Samuel, who said, "The LORD has not chosen this one either." [9] Next Jesse presented Shammah, but Samuel said, "The LORD has not chosen this one either." [10] Thus Jesse made seven of his sons pass before Samuel, but Samuel told him, "The LORD has not chosen any of these."

[11] And Samuel asked him, "Are these all the sons you have?" "There is still the youngest," Jesse replied, "but he is tending the sheep." "Send for him," Samuel replied. "For we will not sit down to eat until he arrives." [12] So Jesse sent for his youngest son and brought him in. He was ruddy, with beautiful eyes and

a handsome appearance. And the LORD said, “Rise and anoint him, for he is
the one.” [13] So Samuel took the horn of oil and anointed him in the presence of his
brothers, and the Spirit of the LORD rushed upon David from that day forward.
Then Samuel set out and went to Ramah. [14] After the Spirit of the LORD had
departed from Saul, a spirit of distress from the LORD began to torment him.

[15] Saul’s servants said to him, “Surely a spirit of distress from God is
tormenting you.” [16] “Let our lord command your servants here to seek out
someone who can skillfully play the harp. Whenever the spirit of distress from
God is upon you, he is to play it, and you will be well.” [17] And Saul commanded
his servants, “Find me someone who plays well, and bring him to me.” [18] One of
the servants answered, “I have seen a son of Jesse of Bethlehem who knows how
to play the harp. He is a mighty man of valor, a warrior, eloquent and handsome,
and the LORD is with him.” [19] So Saul sent messengers to Jesse and said, “Send
me your son David, who is with the sheep.” [20] And Jesse took a donkey loaded
with bread, a skin of wine, and one young goat, and sent them to Saul with his
son David. [21] When David came to Saul and entered his service, Saul admired
him greatly, and David became his armor-bearer. [22] Then Saul sent word to Jesse,
saying, “Let David remain in my service, for I am pleased with him.”